

BASIC BANKING

How to Keep Your Costs Low and Your Money Safe

THERE WAS A time when people's financial lives revolved around their local bank. They got their mortgage there. They obtained their first credit card there. They kept their checking and savings accounts there. They may have even gotten their toaster there.

But that's not true for you, because today many of the services that were once the domain of your local bank are better handled online. You probably went online to shop for an auto loan or to apply for a credit card. Or you may even keep your savings in an Internet-based bank because it pays you higher interest.

So why do you need a bank at all? The main reason is that banks offer two services that are still difficult to get elsewhere: an all-purpose checking account and easy access to your cash through ATMs (automated teller machines). You don't want to settle for just any bank. Your goal is to find the one that gives you those things for the lowest fees and the least hassle.

This chapter will show you how to shop for a bank and how to manage the money you keep there. It will also give you tips on how to cut costs and maximize savings when you bank online. And it will explain how you can keep your money safe, despite the recent turmoil in the banking industry.



A BANK BY ANY OTHER NAME